



Shaping media relations scholarship: A systematic review

Omar Abu Arqoub^{a,*}, Hanadi Dwikat^b

^a Media and Communication Department, Faculty of Graduate Studies, Arab American University, Palestine

^b Dean of Faculty of Modern Media, Arab American University, Palestine

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ABSTRACT

The present meta-analysis study systematically reviews articles on media relations published from 1945 to 2021. It aims to explore media relations research in terms of progression, journals, theories, methods and data analytical tools, media genres and platforms, geospatial distribution of discussed issues and first author affiliations, organization types, most frequently used words, and major themes covered through a quantitative content analysis and a qualitative text mining approach. After applying the inclusion and exclusion criteria, 276 articles from 2006 to 2017 were collected as the final sample. *Public Relations Review* has published the most articles, while the most commonly used theories were agenda setting /building theory, rhetorical theory, and framing theory. Media relations articles utilize qualitative methodologies more than quantitative ones, while the commonly used data analytical tools were content analysis, interview, survey, and case study. Our analysis of the discussed regions and geospatial distribution of first-author show that the North American, European, and Asian continents and the US, the UK, China, and Australia have relatively more publications. The majority of media relations articles discussed governmental organizations. Five themes dominated media relations articles: public relations strategy, media relations practice, mass media and journalism, state-media relations, and organizational media relations.

1. Introduction

Media relations (MR) are central to public relations (PR) and "have long been considered a key facet of public relations" (Verhoeven, 2016, p. 509). MR is a foundational strategy in PR, which attempts to influence the content of media coverage (Diggs-Brown, 2012). Much of the time of many PR practitioners is occupied by MR activities (Bland et al., 2005). Modern PR practice originated from the MR publication of the "Declaration of Principles" in 1906 when Ivy Leadbetter Lee sent his first press release to the media. Then, media were used for all organization types and in propaganda campaigns during the two World Wars (Bland et al., 2005). The relationship between media (earned, paid, owned, social, and live) and PR is crucial and has existed for a long time. Holladay and Coombs (2013) stated, "It is odd that very little is written about media relations given its ubiquity in public relations" (p. 102).

The 22nd International Public Relations Symposium, or BledCom 2015, investigated the different facets of the relationship between PR and mass media under the title "Sleeping with the Media." Conference speakers discussed how current media shape our cultural, economic,

social, lifestyle, and political systems (Verčič et al., 2016). Verčič et al. (2016) explained that MR dates back to a century ago when Walter Lippmann's *Public Opinion* (1922) and Edward Bernays' *Crystallizing Public Opinion* (1923) were published. It is important to discuss the nexus and relationship between media and PR recently because of the acceleration in the development of communication technology and social media.

As Supa and Zoch. (2009) and Taylor (2000) have discussed, MR has been a predominant function of PR practitioners and also the most visible. Despite its important function, there is a lack of systematic frameworks to study MR, with most studies focusing on the tactical rather than strategic and theoretical aspects. Pang et al. (2014) focused on the need for a systematic framework that enables practitioners to examine the environment in which journalists, media organizations, and practitioners operate.

While the field of MR is a practical one, it requires research and reflection to develop further in its practical and theoretical aspects that place MR in the context of the PR profession (Johnston, 2013). Hence, Zerfass et al. (2016) discussed the concept of strategic mediatization as a

Abbreviations: MR, Media Relations; PR, Public Relations; PPR, Public Relations Review.

* Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: omar.abuarqoub@aaup.edu (O. Abu Arqoub), hanadi.dwikat@aaup.edu (H. Dwikat).

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new practice that replaces traditional MR while there is a shift from reliance on mass media to owned digital and social media. Many PR practitioners and researchers see MR as a practical field; meanwhile, this significant field also has its theoretical background that has evolved over the years. Moreover, academic research on MR has increased in the past decades and started to focus on the theoretical side of MR by suggesting new models and using specific theories to direct the practical, theoretical, and academic research of this field. Hence, no comprehensive review of prior MR-focused literature has been conducted applying a systematic meta-analysis, and filling this gap is the main purpose of this study.

A comprehensive systematic literature review of MR research from a communication perspective is important because it can explore the state of knowledge on the topic and provide empirical and scientifically available evidence and interpretation of research directions and trends. It can also help identify research gaps in our current understanding of the MR field. Furthermore, it can highlight methodological concerns in existing research studies, which can be used to improve future work and direct further research and its necessity, and it can help recommend new research ideas for other researchers (Perićić & Tanveer, 2019). The main aim of this research is to examine the progression, journals, methods, data analysis methods, theories, discussed regions, geospatial first author affiliation distribution, discussed organization types, most frequently used words, and major themes found while exploring MR-focused articles.

The present study is not a "state-of-the-art" review and applied restrictive inclusion and exclusion criteria (i.e., not all resource types are explored, such as books and proceedings). The main limitation of this study is that it only focuses on research articles that used the term "media/press relations" published in specific academic databases and communication journals from a communication and PR perspective. However, compared to other meta-analyses in PR, such as that of Pasadeos et al. (2011) that evaluated 250 articles published from 1987 to 2011 or Abu Arqoub et al. (2019) that analyzed 34 articles, the present study has a reasonable sample size of 276 articles.

2. Literature review

2.1. Media relations: an overview

PR practitioners seek to influence mass media because of their reach and credibility in influencing targeted audiences. Even with the rise of the internet and digital media, traditional media such as newspapers, television, and radio are still the most effective channels for getting information and organizational messages across to large audiences in a short time (Theaker, 2012). MR practice entails working with various media to ensure satisfactory publicity of an organization and its policies in a positive, credible, and consistent manner (Feng et al., 2011). Publicity is a wide term referring to the news and information published about an entity, organization, or person that is not purchased, which means that the message appears in media as stories and news rather than ads. Publicity is the result of MR efforts that attract focus to a specific issue, which can be an event, subject, or organization (Feng et al., 2011).

MR also involve two different audiences: the media and the targeted public (Holladay & Coombs, 2013). MR is a powerful tool to persuade audiences, with the media being used to inform relevant public, and in turn, the public can be targeted effectively and specifically. Moreover, editorial coverage conveys implicit endorsement information that is consequently considered more convincing than biased and paid advertising. By using MR effectively, PR practitioners not only enhance their organizations' reputation but also build excellent working relationships with the media and journalists, who can assist them well in the future (Bland et al., 2005). Sound MR practices were crucial to PR campaigns long before people even knew what a PR campaign was (L. Heath, 2013).

PR and MR emerged together, which is one reason why the two concepts are used interchangeably often, especially by PR practitioners

and journalists. Early practitioners were known as press agents and publicists; their target of gaining free press coverage entailed 50% of practitioners using the public information model of PR whose main purpose is information dissemination. "The true purpose of press relations is to enhance the reputation of an organization and its products, and to influence and inform the target audience" (Theaker, 2001, p. 122).

Over the last few decades, there has been growing interest in understanding the tenets of MR. Good MR can contribute to the achievement of longer term strategic objectives, such as improving company/brand image, getting a better media profile, changing the attitudes of target audiences, enhancing relationships with the community, increasing market share, influencing government policy at various levels, improving good communications with main stakeholders as investors, and improving industrial relations (Breakenridge & DeLoughry, 2003; Theaker, 2001). "For some, media exposure is reputation, so if practitioners can influence the media to present a positive image, the job is done" (Theaker, 2012, p. 252). Moreover, MR is one of the bases of sub-field business communications (Carney et al., 2019).

2.2. Media relations area: developments and scholarship

MR has received little attention in the history of PR. In the 18th and 19th centuries, the Houses of Parliament in Britain officially attempted to manage relations with the press. As Maartens (2019) claimed, the management of MR started with the allocation of spaces for reporters in the viewing gallery of the Commons in 1803. The earliest attempts were termed as "media relations management," which was the foundation of the dedicated reporters galleries that was tested out in both parliamentary chambers from 1847 to 1852; moreover, it marked the beginning of Westminster Lobby creation in 1884. This development was vital to the current comprehension of PR and MR history. At the beginning of the 20th century, the UK attempted to bring civil services into the public eye, which was implemented by the governmental PR departments. On the other hand, the 20th century was a remarkable period for the PR profession in the US, which got the opportunity to receive contributions from publicists, press agents, corporations, and voluntary organizations after prolonged attempts since the 19th century to get specific results (Brown, 2014; L'Etang, 2004; Maartens, 2019).

As Heath (2013) declared, the beginning of the 20th century marked MR becoming a practice. This happened when Mary "Mother" Jones moved to Philadelphia in the summer of 1903 to help textile workers protest against the mill owners and bring attention to the main cause of childhood labor tragedy. She created effective MR techniques when she and the union organized "March of the Mill Children" officially, from Philadelphia to President Roosevelt's home on Long Island to enquire about the problem (Steel, 1970). Press conferences were held with the marchers of the press tours, and the children and Mother Jones visited journalists far and wide to tell their stories, make speeches, get more interviews, promote feature stories to journalists, and encourage writers to maintain contact with sources (Heath, 2013; Steel, 1970).

Ivy Lee, who was at the core of MR practices in the early 1900s, worked in Philadelphia for coal operators who were threatened by the strike actions of the United Mine Workers Union. He questioned the Declaration of Principles, which stated that we voted to supply news, our main target is accurate; our plan is to take a hand of press and the general of US prompt. Concerning specific information and subjects which hold the value and the interest to people to help them no more about it (Grunig & Hunt, 1984; Steel, 1970; Theaker, 2001). Ivy Lee started to practice MR after the establishment of his own PR agency in 1916; he was aware that he held the entire PR responsibility for the Rockefeller family and organizing relations with media for them (Hebert, 1966).

For the literature published in academic journals specializing in PR, there were a few studies and articles published from the 1940–1960 s focusing on the terms "media relations and press relations," for example,

Alexander's (1966) study titled "Space Flight News: NASA's Press Relations and Media Reaction," Hutchison's (1961) study titled "Kennedy and the Press: The First Six Months," Goldsmith's (1956) study titled "Reporting the Civil War: Union Army Press Relations," Rutland's (1955) study titled "The Army Seeks a 'Good' Press," Cornwell's (1962) study titled "Press Conferences of Woodrow Wilson," Pollard's (1951) article titled "President Truman and the Press," and Pollard's (1945) article titled "Franklin D. Roosevelt And the Press." Most of these articles discussed state-MR and studied how country and government institutions deal and build relationships with media and journalists. Following this, many research articles, conference papers, and book chapters used these terms and discussed other sides of MR.

In the same context, the journal *Public Relations Review* published the only special issue on MR in 2016 by collecting the papers that the 22nd International Public Relations Symposium discussed (Verčič et al., 2016). Verhoeven (2016) conducted a collective framing of the mediation moderation model based on reviews of 50 years of literature that contained the relationship between PR and mass media. The study shows scientific literature, between 1963 and 2013, on news media and businesses that created strong relationships with journalists and PR professionals. Tkalc Verčič and Colić. (2016) reported the animosity between PR practitioners and journalists, a big theme, which decreased only when journalists started to view PR as modern MR.

Additionally, Galloway (2016) assessed MR activities applied by the Islamic State (ISIS), which is considered a symbolic and strategic "Media jihad" form from which PR practitioners can learn. Fredriksson and Pallas (2016) discussed the process of what is called mediatization, which is a double-edged process in which media have their own rationalities set and then emerge as autonomous institutions that enable them to integrate with other institutions. Savič (2016) also explored mediatization, contending that foundations are fast introduced as producers of special media and media content for different modes of managed communications that control stakeholders. On the other hand, the stakeholders determine the main role of PR.

Eventually, Zerfass et al. (2016) operationalized the main principle of the "strategic mediatization" concept as a main practice that supplements or replaces the frame of traditional MR, also calling it a movement from a base of mass media to owned media. The review of the articles presented findings about the status of MR in Europe; it reflects the upcoming media movement from mass-mediated communication to specific production of content delivery back to the strategic communicators. In the 20th century, this paved the way for a new platform for various kinds of MR to be equipped with new forms of mediatized content. The literature review spots a core introduction about the concept of "strategic mediatization" being renamed as the modern practice supplementing and even replacing the old-fashioned MR. This has helped the current study to include many suggestions for future research and creates a new purpose of having a modified comprehension of "strategic mediatization" (Zerfass et al., 2016, p. 507).

The literature reveals two major issues in MR. The first is based on the predominant information subsidy, for example, press releases and interviews. That was clear as a main strategy for MR. PR has increased for new generations and has widely influenced the media agenda that was built and framed by different issues. Second, the prevention of MR practices is characterized by the shortcomings in terms of transparency of professional and ethical impact. PR has been labeled by Western democracies, including the use of media and PR to impact the mindset of the public (Hou, 2019). An academic perspective has come into prominence: The effect of emphasizing the central focus of PR should exhibit a great leap from mere communication to relationship management. In terms of the relational paradigm, the field of MR has maintained and kept in line with the importance that it has held since the early times of PR, and this has become the main focus of organizing relations with mass media and journalists (Taşkıran, 2016).

In the 20th century, mass media have been the main channels for reaching customers, public, and all other kinds of stakeholders and to

constitute and convey meaning. Relating to society and historical contexts, media have been developed and embedded widely in different countries. The creation of media agenda that has also been dominated by the media system has led MR to become a more crucial part of PR (Zerfass et al., 2016). Likewise, Taylor (2000) explained that "Hallahan suggested that new technology may actually cut the media out of the public relations loop" (pp. 3–4). Unlike Grunig, "Hallahan viewed this diminished relationship between organizations and the media as a negative outcome because 'a loss of public reliance upon and confidence in the mass media could be devastating for public relations, journalism, and for society-at-large'" (Taylor, 2000, p. 4). With the rise of new communication technologies such as social media and new forms of targeting stakeholders directly, traditional MR are challenging to adapt new concepts. Only a few studies have specifically investigated how new technologies and social media shape the relationship between PR practitioners and journalists as well as online MR (Zerfass et al., 2016).

2.3. Definition of media relations

In *Fundamentals of Public Relations*, Mark Hunter LaVigne (2015) offers an advanced definition of MR and makes a critical differentiation between MR and other PR and communication strategies:

Media relations is the art and science of reaching your target audience with key messages through the news media. Media relations is one of PR's main practice areas and, arguably, one of the most difficult. It is one of the only communications disciplines that goes through a gatekeeper—news media—to reach the end audience. The media relations strategy that enables key messages to pass through the gatekeeper is easily applied to other marketing communications disciplines. Finding the newsworthiness in a message necessarily removes non-essential information. It focuses organizations intellectually to get down to their brass tacks: to keep their messages simple, to the point and honest. (LaVigne, 2015 as cited in Carney et al., 2019, pp. 29–30).

As Johnston (2013) mentioned, MR is a special type of 20 or more roles and basic materials for the practitioners of PR and is unilaterally necessary for all sectors in society: the political, corporate, and non-profit sectors. Moreover, there are other definitions of MR that help establish how we understand the field and provide some parameters and key elements: "Media relations is the ongoing facilitation and coordination of communication and relationships between an individual, group or organisation and the media" (p. 14). This definition explores MR from a practitioner's point of view as having a dual role within media, especially as a communicator although there is a precise relationship manager (Johnston, 2013).

MR is about managing professional relationships to understand and adapt the way your counterparts operate professionally by considering the timeframes and deadlines through various shapes or activities of the profession and use media as a barometer for social recognition as well as to establish a foundation in different areas, which also helps promote and organize the coverage of media tips and aligns with the MR iceberg concept (Johnston, 2013). Shaw and White (2004) argued that MR are "like the tip of an iceberg – the most visible part, but certainly not all there is" (p. 494). However, MR is a complex process that includes different MR strategies, journalists, editors, MR professionals, and media enterprises (Zerfass et al., 2016). In MR, practitioners depend on favorable publicity for the different products that the organization offers and even services applied through information subsidy to boost the organization's reputation (Feng et al., 2011; Pang, 2010; Theaker, 2012). Furthermore, MR can be expressed and shown as communicating with media experts, journalists, and editors from different media outlets and within internet-based communication atmospheres at local, international, and sectoral levels (Taşkıran, 2016).

2.4. Media relations as a public relations strategy

The MR function of PR is an unavoidable component of most

campaigns and organizations. MR has traditionally concentrated on the practitioners' ability to communicate and earn their place in a variety of mass media to ensure placement in the main news stories for the organization. Here, media placement not only educates and informs the audience about topics but also serves as a tangible demonstration of practitioners' efforts (Waters et al., 2011). By using MR, organizations seek to get more positive impressions of the targeted public through the creation of news stories called media coverage, which is a means to an end (Holladay & Coombs, 2013). Hence, MR practice is considered the main PR strategy (Feng et al., 2011).

MR derives its importance from the media's gatekeeping role of controlling the flows of information to the public in our social system. Hence, MR serves the functions of keeping media contacts, figuring out newsworthy stories that the media seeks, and placing news releases about organizations of all types—not-for-profit, non-governmental, business, and even terrorist organizations such as ISIS—to deliver their messages to the targeted public (Galloway, 2016; Taylor, 2000). Moreover, each organization has its own limitations, especially in terms of information that can be released; for example, governments have precise legal limitations about what to release and not, while advocacy groups have fewer restrictions (Carney et al., 2019). (Figs. 1 and 2).

MR comprises several vital PR tactics. First, with media catching, practitioners usually initiate contact with the media and respond to journalists' requests by being available and completing a news story (Tallapragada et al., 2012). Second, commitment to deadlines is crucial for both practitioners and journalists in novel MR (Waters et al., 2011). Third, work activities and initiatives include pitching stories, writing press releases and speeches, writing backgrounders, fact sheets, traditional and online ways of distribution releases, offering content photos, video, and audio materials, training organizational spokespersons, media kits, coordinating publicity, identifying audiences, monitoring media coverage, and measuring media engagement efforts, media advisories, organizing news conferences and interviews, maintaining media distribution lists updated, letters to the editor, update the online organizational web and information, emails, Twitter, and Facebook postings, YouTube videos, blogs, leaks, and phone calls (Feng et al., 2011; Johnston, 2013; Pang et al., 2014; Sha, 2011).

As Heath (2013) and Wilson and Supa. (2013) stated, modern MR experts use these techniques and a few others: distributing videos to broadcast outlets and websites, asking journalists about their information needs periodically, preparing media packets, and preparing managers to interact with journalists. Moreover, ethical practitioners are obligated to keep the mass media informed because journalists are going



Fig. 2. Word cloud of MR articles (Top 100 words).

to write newsworthy stories and press releases with or without input from practitioners; thus, it is in their best interest for professional practitioners to be involved. Six well-known values increase the newsworthiness of journalists: timeliness, impact, audience interest, conflict or oddity, drama, and human interest (Holladay & Coombs, 2013).

Other important tactics for good MR stated by Heath (2013) and others (Comrie, 1997; Page & Adams, 2014; Reyes, 2018) are as follows: provide sound information—practitioners should deliver credible, accurate, relevant, timely, fair, complete information; write and speak carefully—practitioners must master language components such as punctuation, grammar, spelling, and style, and the information should contain interests and values and be in journalistic format combined with a lead of 10–30; communication during crisis—an organization should release only verified information that is accurate, carefully avoid intentionally misleading or holding information, express concerns in the right way, prepare for the worst that could happen, and have proactive plans and provide full information about the crisis, such as time of accident, cause, number of injuries, damage estimate; talking back by

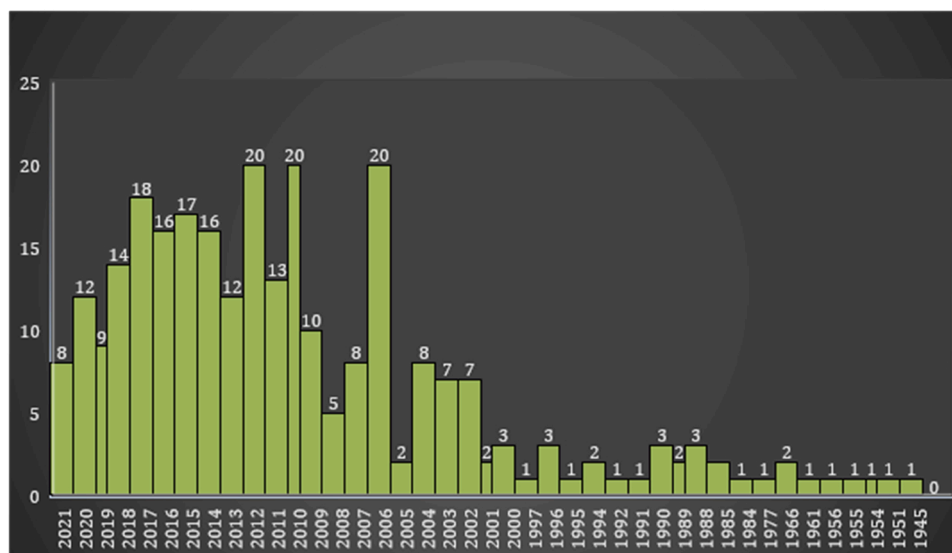


Fig. 1. yearly progression of MR-focused research.

having friendly relations with local media journalists and representatives to follow, correct, and criticize media coverage or lack thereof (L. Heath, 2013).

MR is part of the bigger picture of PR, and it is usually classified as a technical side of PR work (Johnston, 2013; Pang, 2010). MR requires more complex skills that can leverage media to publish a message or control a news story; these skills include strategic planning and application, succinct and clear writing, careful and deep research, and systematic evaluation (Johnston, 2013; Pang et al., 2014). Moreover, PR is described as relationship management and positioned as a function of management that develops, establishes, and maintains the relationship between organizations and their target public strategically. Hence, the relationship management process facilitates the formation of positive and long-term relationships with journalists and media by applying relationship maintenance strategies, such as positivity, networking, assurances, openness, and sharing of tasks (Breakenridge & DeLoughry, 2003; Taşkıran, 2016).

2.5. Online media relations

Online MR uses crowdsourcing, which emerged as a reference point for the use of new technologies in MR and the changes that were subsequently made. This includes emerging technologies such as social media newsrooms, online press rooms, the Facebook initiative (Instant Articles), specific applications for targeting media, and journalists such as HARO (Help a Reporter Out) are shaping MR (Verčič, Verčič, & Sriramesh, 2015; Zeffass et al., 2016). Researchers have examined MR as a strategic function of PR (Atabek & Alikilic, 2020; Billard, 2021; Theaker, 2012; Verčič et al., 2015; Zeffass et al., 2016). Meanwhile, the process of making MR campaigns and programs and even the roles in the field are changing because of the advent of new media forms within media organizations and media systems. Today, organizations explore new MR practices depending on new technological tools. They practice content marketing by paying to publish content for target audiences or for content appearing in the intended form and platforms, such as native advertising or embedded marketing, and Facebook posts to promote brands, ideas, and products, depending on individual journalistic sense and skills.

Social media relations involves many activities, including developing social media strategies for PR and communications efforts, utilizing web-based social networks, producing in-house or client blogs, using social media as delivery channels for PR and communications efforts, SEO, building blogger relations, etc. (Sha, 2011; Wilson and Supa., 2013). Furthermore, a fascinating aspect of social media relations is its ability to target a specific audience defined by a range of demographic, geographic, psychological, behavioral, and specialist interest measures, which makes MR practitioners believe that they have the ability to deliver to the public, as discussed in the literature (Bajkiewicz et al., 2011; Jiang et al., 2017; Pang et al., 2016; Theaker, 2012; Waters et al., 2010; Yoo & Kim, 2013).

2.6. Related theoretical background

According to Habermas (1989 [1962]) as cited in Zeffass et al. (2016), for a long time, public spheres were controlled by mass media through gatekeeping, agenda setting and agenda building, framing, priming, etc. Modern PR originated from MR as represented by Grunig and Hunt's (1984) press agency model by using media as a tool to generalize information and enhance organizations' influence. Moreover, it is now considered the digital and social media age where the other relations of media still account for 60–70% of all PR efforts (Hou, 2019; Zoch & Molleda., 2006).

Carroll and McCombs (2003) introduced the agenda-setting theory to illustrate how the first and the second agenda levels affect stakeholders' principles for the foundation. They also posited that more ideas would lead to higher awareness of the organization and that coverage is

given through particular attributes of organizations' stakeholders. Moreover, the use of these attributes can define and better the organization. According to the agenda setting theory, the levels and parts of media agenda can provide insights into the factors that impact the targeted sector of public agenda. The points emerging from the review of this theory showed that information originating outside an organization from PR participation and engagement with media agenda has a specific public agenda. This perspective suggests that PR can play an effective role in bringing intensive organizational content and a wide range of special audiences by having powerful control (Măiorescu, 2016; Pang et al., 2014; Taşkıran, 2016; Waters, 2013; Waters & Tindall, 2011).

Carroll and McCombs (2003) discussed how agenda setting affects people's attention through topics in the news. The central theoretical idea is "the transfer of salience from the media agenda to the public agenda," (p.36) which is consistent with the idea of business communication. Carroll and McCombs indicated five key theoretical propositions about the influence of news coverage on corporate reputations among the public.

These five propositions as mentioned in Carroll & McCombs (2003, pp. 39–42) are:

- First, "The amount of news coverage that a firm receives in the news media is positively related to the public's awareness of the firm."
- Second, "The amount of news coverage devoted to particular attributes of a firm is positively related to the proportion of the public who define the firm by those attributes."
- Third, "The more positive that media coverage is for a particular attribute, the more positively will members of the public perceive that attribute. Conversely, the more negative that media coverage is for a particular attribute, the more negatively will members of the public perceive that attribute."
- Fourth, "The agenda of substantive and affective attributes associated with a firm in business news coverage, especially those attributes specifically linked with a firm, primes the public's attitude and opinion about the firm."
- Fifth, "Organized efforts to communicate a corporate agenda will result in a significant degree of correspondence between the attribute agenda of the firm and the news media."

However, according to the level of agenda-building theory, media agenda is not established within the newsroom as much as it should be built by the source of information provided. Media support their agenda via the information subsidy that PR practitioners offer (Feng et al., 2011; Hou, 2019; Ohl et al., 1995; Ragas, 2013; Salwen, 1995; Schafrad et al., 2016a, 2016b; Weitkamp & Eidsvaag, 2014). Ohl et al. (1995) stated that agenda building in PR refers to "sources' interactions with gatekeepers, a give-and-take process in which sources seek to get their information published and the press seeks to get that information from independent sources" (Ohl et al., 1995, p. 91).

However, the emergence of social media and many other new online platforms creates far more news and information than any individual can consume. The traditional agenda-setting approach seems insufficient to capture the complexity of the current media environment (Guo & Vargo, 2015). The most recent agenda-setting studies explored "the extent to which the news media can transfer the salience of relationships among a set of elements to the public" (McCombs et al., 2014, p. 792). Guo and McCombs (2011) assumed that the media can not only influence the salience of certain topics in public agendas, but they can also influence how the public relates these topics to one another. They also presented a new theoretical model called the Network Agenda Setting Model (NAS), which they refer to as the third-level agenda setting. This model shows that "the news media can bundle sets of objects or attributes and make these bundles of elements salient in the public's mind simultaneously." (p.6) In other words, elements in people's minds are not linear, as traditional approaches indicate; instead, they are interconnected with each other to make a network-like structure in one's

mind; and if the news media always mention two elements together, the audience will perceive these two elements as interconnected (Guo & McCombs, 2011; Guo & Vargo, 2015; Su & Hu, 2020).

The NAS model focuses on the interconnections among issues and attributes rather than on individual elements. It investigates the news media's ability to influence how people connect various messages in their minds. It asserts that news media have the power to construct new connections and enhance current ones. The core hypothesis of the NAS model asserts that the ways in which news media associate various messages, ideas, and concepts (e.g., the 9/11 attack and Saddam Hussein's regime) dictate the way the public makes associations (Guo & McCombs, 2011). From the perspective of cognitive psychology, the NAS model measures the associative model of memory, which enables understanding social reality as a picture where numerous nodes are connected to one another while nodes can be single words, objects, and their attributes, which reveals more contextual information about how people make sense of the world. Simply put, the more frequently two elements are associated in the news coverage, the more likely it is that the audience will consider the two interconnected (Guo & McCombs, 2011; Guo & Vargo, 2015; Su & Hu, 2020).

Baskin et al. (1997) discussed as cited in Holladay and Coombs (2013) that, for the gatekeeping theory, media members influence the merging of the selected news items, especially the use of news in different stages and events, even when some cases are completely ignored and other are reported as news. Journalists identify the information that is worthy of being news and thus act as gatekeepers who shape the wide-ranging news presented for targeted audiences by using mass media tools. PR practitioners modify the role of journalists as intended audiences, using them as a tool to reach wider audiences and as gatekeepers who represent and reflect the needs of any news information. The news media gatekeepers are objectively the initial and basic key for MR to generate news stories. The practitioners of PR initiate possible stories for newspapers, even the form of news that is released, which are then sent to the news media by stimulating a specific story. Practitioners use news-worthy information or valuable and potential stories that hold important ideas and those which aim to attract media attention (Hecht et al., 2017; Holladay & Coombs, 2013; Lee & Berkowitz, 2004).

The framing theory indicates the possibility of information originating from PR fields, which is then received and deemed appropriate for the expectations of the audiences and to fulfil media needs, for gaining the approval of gatekeepers and reaching a wide range of targeted audiences. Using the suggestions of the framing theory by commanding the media process, wherein specific stories are framed for affective and active journalism, practitioners can increase the possibility of the information showing up clearly in the media (Taşkıran, 2016). Zoch and Molleda (2006) and Holladay and Coombs (2013) claimed that framing is beneficial as a perspective to explain how PR practitioners can be monitored and to promote news that can reach the objective of their true goal: the public.

Other models of MR suggested by Zoch and Molleda (2006) focus on the foundational processes that are used to create campaign or program by MR specialists as strategic tools for PR, regardless of the existing media field systems and its level of influence on areas of strategic MR. On the other hand, the intereffication model by Bentele and Nothhaft (2008) explains the relationship between the mass media sector and the reputation of PR on three different dimensions: organizations, complementary systems, and individual professionals (Lee et al., 2018). The model, improved by Yoon (2005), explains MR from the perspective of practitioners' ability to impact journalists. Called the Media Access Model, Yoon (2005) explored the expertise of practitioners and journalists' perceptions, which they could predict from having access to the media. Expertise is examined from the perspective of what journalists regard from a legal point of view. This supports the reflection of impressive status, competence, legality, credibility, and stability (Sherwood et al., 2017).

Based on Yoon's (2005) call for an enhanced approach to understanding journalists and journalism, this author has developed the mediating the media model, which is a journalist-centric MR model. This model is adapted from and inspired by Shoemaker and Reese's (1996) theory called Mediating the Message influences on media content. Pang's (2010) journalist-centric Mediating the Media model aims to equip practitioners with a huge and comprehensive framework to cultivate MR. This model shows two sets of internal and external influences. The internal ones include journalistic mindsets, newsroom routines, and journalist routines. External influences include media ideology and extra-media forces. The model seeks to win journalists by the knowledge of their profession extending beyond the function of information subsidy (Atabek & Alikilic, 2020; Pang et al., 2014).

Mediating the Media model supposes that practitioners should be aware of the need to support engagement in proactive MR, which is also recognized as their own responsibility to cultivate excellent MR points, gather an understanding of how journalists express their ideas via media, and show how they operate news in a specific environment (Pang, 2010; Pang et al., 2014). The significance of this model is threefold. **First**, it helps encourage practitioners to look deep into the information and strategic thinking function of MR in organizations. Thinking strategically showed up as a process in which the following are done: re-evaluating practitioners, re-enacting specific operational concerns, and reaffirming different news. **Second**, it is an effective approach to gain complete understanding of journalists and journalism according to practitioners and certain ideas that can lead to stronger media with greater access of MR sectors, even leading to a wider, stronger public presence, and a better image of the organization. **Third**, as Yoon (2005) discussed, this model asks practitioners to focus "more on learning about how the media and journalists operate and use that knowledge to build, change, or maintain journalists' perceptions of their organizations." (Pang, 2010, p. 193).

Ultimately, and after all the above interpretations, MR is a mature PR research area and strategy. This article seeks to shape MR scholarship (articles) from a communication perspective by addressing the following research questions:

1. How has published MR research progressed over the years?
2. What journals published the highest number of MR-focused research?
3. What are the most frequently used theories in published MR research?
4. What are the major methods adopted in published MR research?
5. What specific analytical methods were adopted within the published MR scholarship?
6. What media genres and platforms were explored in published MR research?
7. What is the geospatial distribution of issues discussed in MR research?
8. What is the geospatial distribution of first author affiliations within MMR articles?
9. What organization types are discussed within the published MR articles?
10. What are the most frequently used words and themes in published MR scholarship?

3. Method

The present exploratory study systematically peer-reviewed, MR-focused research over the last decades. In order to comprehensively understand how published research on MR has evolved in terms of progression, journals, theories, methodologies, media genres and platforms, geospatial distribution, major themes/categories, and most frequently used words, quantitative content analysis and qualitative text mining approaches were used.

3.1. Data collection method

For acquiring a sizeable number of empirical peer-reviewed, MR-focused research, articles published in well-known international academic databases (Online Bibliographic and Full Text Databases) were sought. These databases were explored based on their reputation and publication of highly impactful journals that publish quality empirical peer-reviewed studies in the field of communication (Abu Arqoub et al., 2019; Abu Arqoub et al., 2020). For articles to qualify as MR-focused research to be added to our sample frame, they had to be full-text empirical studies written in the English language and published in the field of communication. The keywords "press relations" and "media relations" were used to search for MR-centered research, and the following inclusion and exclusion criteria were adopted. To explain the systematic search method and criteria, Table 1 shows the number of articles in each database and the stringent criteria of inclusion and exclusion that was adopted.

The criteria used excluded and included articles based on their titles, abstracts, and keywords. Overall, our search result generated 1136 articles but, after applying our inclusion and exclusion criteria, a total of 276 MR articles qualified and were therefore included in our sample.

3.2. Coding scheme

To ascertain the content of the MR research, the following coding scheme, including categories and definitions, was created. To review the yearly progression of MR-focused research, the researchers coded the articles' years of publication from 1945 to 2021, based on the database search outcomes. To review most of the theories used by MR-related research, the categories were identified and then coded. Similarly, journals that published MR research were coded. The researchers determine what theories, journals, and regions have been discussed and their first-author affiliations based on the categories were identified, the previous studies, and what were found within the sample which other similar studies did as (Arqoub et al., 2019, 2020; Elegu & Özad, 2018; Elegu et al., 2022).

With regard to media genres and platforms, based on research conducted by Arqoub et al. (2019; 2020), media genre is the type or kind of media generation used in the studied communication process, which in our case includes traditional media, digital media, and social media. Media platform is the exact type of media outlets used in the mass communication process to contact the audience. Studies have analyzed the content and usage of media platforms, such as television, radio, Facebook, and Twitter.

To ascertain patterns in the kind of methods used in MR research, based on studies conducted by Arqoub et al. (2019; 2020), Baxter and Connolly (2013), and Wasike (2017), the following categories were coded and modified: (1) qualitative methods, (2) quantitative methods, (3) mixed methods, and (4) others. As for the specific analytical methods

used, the following categories were applied: (1) case study, (2) rhetoric analysis, (3) content analysis, (4) survey, (5) mixed methods, (6) document analysis, (7) interviews, (8) secondary data, (9) experimental, (10) historical analysis, (11) ethnography, (12) focus groups, (13) textual analysis, (14) review, (15) framing analysis, (16) discourse analysis, (17) thematic analysis, (18) Comparative Analysis, (19) interpretive analysis, (20) multiple, and (21) others.

To determine first-author affiliation by university/institution that produced most MR-related research and first-author affiliation by program/departments, the researchers coded what they found and categorized tables based on frequency to determine the universities and programs that most frequently produced MR articles.

For the types of organizations that MR research focused on and discussed, we adopted what we found and coded it into the following categories: (1) no organization, (2) government organizations, (3) profit organizations (private sector and companies), (4) non-government/civil organizations, and (5) mixed organizations.

The text-mining approach was adopted to interpret the Word Cloud and find the most frequently used words and themes within MR research, which this study aims to recognize clearly from the collected articles' texts. The NVivo 12 program was adopted to extract the most commonly used words and the most significant themes. The Word Frequency Test was conducted to determine the most frequently used words, and a list of the most frequently used terms was obtained from our sample (see word cloud diagram). Moreover, the study interpreted the main themes by examining the most used words to see if there was a relationship between the keywords/terms and the context in which they were explored in the articles. Similar and related terms were classified and grouped after evaluating the keywords, resulting in the categories presented (themes/nodes), and each theme was operationally defined according to the context and discussions within the articles.

3.3. Coding process

The inter-rater reliability test was conducted to ensure the success of the coding process. Using Cohen's kappa coefficient formula (Cohen, 1960), two experts and communication researchers in the field of communication, media studies, and PR conducted the coding process, with a single MR-focused article being the analysis unit. The inter-rater agreement between the two researchers of the (276) articles occurred at K= (91%), with the complete agreement percentage being (1.00). According to Cohen's formula, values from (0.81) to (1.00) are considered excellent, making our result highly reliable.

4. Results

Overall, our search result generated a total of 1136 articles. Based on the inclusion and exclusion criteria, a total of 276 MR-focused articles qualified out of the search results and were therefore included in our

Table 1
Databases, search outcomes, and inclusion/exclusion criteria for MR articles.

Database	Search Outcome	Inclusion Criteria	Exclusion Criteria	No. of Certified Papers
Elsevier Science Direct	365	Journal articlesPeer-reviewedFull-text articles	Articles do not contain press/MR in their title, keywords, or abstract	33
EBSCO's	296	Contained in one of the academic databases	Articles do not focus on press/MR in their body (some articles only mentioned the terms in their abstract but did not explore it). Conference papers,	34
Communication & Mass Media Complete		exploredOnly articles written in English	books, book chapters, and other academic resources.	
SAGE Journals	52	languageKeywords: press/MR must be mentioned in either the title, keywords, or abstract	Articles we could not access, either using the virtual library or through physical copies	26
Taylor and Francis Online	79	Articles published only within the communication fieldDo not duplicated	Other languagesOther fields that are not communication, or related to communication	61
Web of science	251		Short papers that have no analysis and reference lists	111
JSTOR	35		Book reviewsRepeated or duplicated articles	2
ProQuest Central	85			9
Total	1136			276

sample. This section presents the results regarding the progression, theories, methodologies, data collection methods, publications by discussed regions, affiliation of first authors, discussed organization types, most frequently used words, and major themes in MR-focused articles.

As shown in the figure below, 1945 was considered as the starting date for publication of MR-focused articles. From this date till 2001, the number of the articles reached (31), indicating that the field was growing slowly over this period. From 2002–2017, the number of published articles increased steadily; notably, 2006, 2010, and 2012 have the highest publication numbers, with 20 articles each year. This relates to the rise of research focused on traditional media and traditional PR combined with the rise of digital media and Web 2.0. In the last four years, from 2018 to 2021, the number of articles decreased steadily, which could be due to the rise of digital and social media and researchers focusing less on traditional MR. Overall, these results indicate that MR research is an interesting and evolving research area, especially in the recent 20 years. (Tables 2–7).

As the above table shows, the highest number of MR scholarship was published in specialized PR journals, such as Public Relations Review, Journal of Public Relations Research, Public Relations Inquiry, and International Journal of Strategic Communication. This indicates the importance of this field for PR journals. The next highest number of MR research occurs in journals specialized in communication, with a focus on sub areas, such as journalism, management, media, press and politics, and business and marketing communication. This indicates that MR has shaped research on PR and overlaps with various sub-fields of communication.

This table shows that 114 articles applied theoretical frameworks while discussing MR. Interestingly, 172 did not. Between the 114 used theoretical frameworks, 14 articles used multiple theories together; for example, framing and agenda-setting theory and strategic issue management theory and social responsibility theory. The most used specific theories – agenda-setting and agenda-building theories – had 18 articles. Rhetorical theory was applied in 10 articles, framing theory in 8 articles, mediatization theory in 6 articles, dialogic communication theory in 5 articles, and image repair theory and contingency theory in 3 articles each. This shows the variety of communication and specific PR theories used in MR areas, and it indicates the PR perspective of thinking about MR. 25 articles used other theories, such as excellence theory and stakeholder's theory.

The above table shows results for the two important variables of the present study's methods and data collection techniques. As can be seen, most of the articles (N = 149) used qualitative methods that are designated by the identified data collection methods, such as interviews, case study, reviews, historical analysis, discourse analysis, and comparative and thematic analysis. There were fewer studies (N = 93) that used quantitative methods, including surveys, content analysis, and experimental analysis. These results demonstrate that MR articles discuss issues and case studies extensively, and the nature of the field requires understanding the issue from multiple angles, which qualitative methods help with. Furthermore, future studies should use more

Table 2
Journals that published MR-focused articles.

Journals	Frequency	Percent
Valid		
Public Relations Review	95	34.4
Harvard International Journal of Press/Politics	15	5.4
Journal of Communication Management	13	4.7
Journalism & Mass Communication Quarterly	11	4.0
Journalism Studies	10	3.6
Journal of Public Relations Research	9	3.3
Public Relations Inquiry	6	2.2
Journalism	5	1.8
Asian Journal of Communication	5	1.8
International Journal of Strategic Communication	5	1.8
Others	102	36.9
Total	276	100.0

Table 3
Theoretical framework of MR-focused research.

Theories	Frequency	Percent
Valid		
No Theory	172	62.3
Multiple Theories	14	5.1
Agenda setting Theory	10	3.6
Rhetorical Theory	10	3.6
Framing Theory	8	2.9
Agenda-Building Theory	8	2.9
Dialogic Communication Theory	5	1.8
Mediatization Theory	6	2.1
Image Repair Theory	3	1.1
Contingency Theory	3	1.1
Gatekeeping Theory	2	0.7
Relationship Management Theory	2	0.7
Critical Theory	2	0.7
State-Press/MR Theory	2	0.7
Cultural Theory	2	0.7
Institutional Theory	2	0.7
Other Theories	25	9
Total	276	100.0

Table 4
Methodologies used within media relation scholarship.

Methods	Frequency	Percent
Valid		
Qualitative	149	54.0
Quantitative	93	33.7
Mixed	34	12.3
Total	276	100.0
Data Analytical Techniques	Frequency	Percent
Valid		
Content Analysis	46	16.7
Interviews	46	16.7
Survey	44	15.9
Case Study	40	14.5
More Than One/Multiple	37	13.4
Review	19	6.9
Historical Analysis	15	5.4
Experimental Analysis	4	1.4
Framing Analysis	4	1.4
Ethnography	3	1.1
Discourse Analysis	3	1.1
Comparative Analysis	3	1.1
Interpretive Analysis	2	0.7
Thematic Analysis	2	0.7
Others	8	2.8
Total	276	100.0

Table 5
Media genres and platforms of MR research.

Media Genre	Frequency	Percent
Valid		
No Media Genre	168	60.9
Traditional Media	59	21.4
Digital Media	34	12.3
Multiple Genres	11	4.0
Social Media	4	1.4
Total	276	100.0
Media Platforms	Frequency	Percent
Valid		
No Media Platforms	170	61.6
Newspapers	34	12.3
Multiple Platforms	24	8.7
Organizations' Online Websites	18	6.5
Online News Websites	13	4.7
Television	11	4.0
Twitter	2	0.7
Radio	1	0.4
Magazines	1	0.4
Blogs	1	0.4
Wikipedia	1	0.4
Total	276	100.0

Table 6

Continents and countries discussed within MR articles.

Continent Discussed		Frequency	Percent
Valid	North America	105	38.0
	Europe	53	19.2
	Asia	44	15.9
	More Than One	26	9.4
	No Continent	25	9.1
	Australia	15	5.4
	Africa	6	2.2
	South America	2	0.7
	Total	276	100.0
Countries Discussed		Frequency	Percent
Valid	USA	98	35.5
	No Country	30	10.9
	Multiple Countries	26	9.4
	UK	15	5.4
	China	13	4.7
	Australia	11	4.0
	South Korea	7	2.5
	New Zealand	5	1.8
	Netherlands	4	1.4
	Singapore	4	1.4
	Canada	4	1.4
	Nigeria	4	1.4
	Spain	3	1.1
	Poland	3	1.1
	Turkey	3	1.1
	Russia	3	1.1
	Serbia	3	1.1
	Others	40	14.4
	Total	276	100.0

Table 7

First Authors' Affiliations by continents and countries.

First Author by Continent		Frequency	Percent
Valid	North America	140	50.7
	Europe	63	22.8
	Asia	37	13.4
	Australia	25	9.1
	Africa	6	2.2
	More than One	3	1.1
	South America	2	0.7
	Total	276	100.0
First Author by Country		Frequency	Percent
Valid	USA	136	49.3
	Australia	19	6.9
	UK	19	6.9
	China	9	3.3
	Singapore	8	2.9
	New Zealand	6	2.2
	South Korea	6	2.2
	Netherlands	5	1.8
	Canada	5	1.8
	Spain	4	1.4
	Germany	4	1.4
	Nigeria	4	1.4
	Others	54	19.5
	Total	276	100.0

quantitative and mixed methods to measure different kinds of variables for obtaining a practical PR strategy.

The table above shows that many articles do not discuss or analyze any media genres or platforms that discuss the profession itself and view MR as the practical side of PR in addition to the many reviews, interviews, and historical data that are used and analyzed. Most notably, there was a lack of articles examining social media genres and platforms, which is strange in light of the rise of social media in the last decade. In contrast, a large number of articles (N = 56) have discussed and analyzed traditional media genres and platforms through articles focused on newspapers, television, and traditional media coverage. Meanwhile, the digital media genres and platforms have (N = 34)

articles that include the organization's website and news website.

The above table explains the importance of MR based on the places discussed within MR scholarship. It shows that, mainly, developed countries were discussed significantly more, which is normal considering that PR originated in these places and all kinds of media has been developed and used there first. Also, these places have developed organizations and corporations all over the world. With regard to continents, North America had 105 articles and Europe had 53 articles. The most discussed countries were USA with 98 articles and UK with 15 articles. Africa and South America had the lowest number of articles. Further, 30 articles – along with review and literature articles – did not discuss any continent or country and instead focused on discussing the field itself and professions within it.

The present table clearly shows the interest of American researchers and universities in MR, with North America being the continent with the highest number of articles (140), while USA had 136 articles. This is a reasonable number and related to the American level of research productivity and number of researchers and journals. This is followed by Europe with 63 articles, while countries that mostly focused on MR include UK (19), Netherlands, and Spain. Asian researchers and universities published 37 articles, mostly in China and Singapore. Australia published 25 articles, followed by Africa with only 6 articles, while South America had the lowest number of published MR articles. These results are similar to the discussed places within MR scholarship, which reflects that developed countries are more interested in MR as a practice and research topic.

As shown in Table 8, almost 74% of the articles were published from various universities worldwide. This indicates that various universities published MR research with no clear high concentration of specific institutions in searching a sub-PR area. There were a few universities that focused on PR and MR, including the University of Kentucky, Nanyang Technological University, and the University of Georgia, which published six articles each. Other universities that conducted less MR research were Texas Tech University and the University of Amsterdam (five articles) and North Carolina State University, the University of Oklahoma, Massey University, and the University of Florida (four articles). Very diverse universities published the rest of the articles.

As shown in Table 9, MR is a communication research area, even though some research has been conducted from other perspectives and areas. Communication researchers who are teaching and managing communication programs and departments worldwide (e.g., journalism, media, mass communication, advertising, and public relations) have published most MR articles (70.2%, N = 190). Other programs and departments were far fewer with different ranges. Under political science

Table 8

First-Authors' Affiliations in Terms of Institution/University.

Institution		Frequency	Percent
Valid	Others	205	74.3
	The University of Kentucky	6	2.2
	Nanyang Technological University	6	2.2
	The University of Georgia	6	2.2
	Texas Tech University	5	1.8
	University of Amsterdam	5	1.8
	North Carolina State University	4	1.4
	The University of Oklahoma	4	1.4
	Massey University	4	1.4
	University of Florida	4	1.4
	Renmin University of China	3	1.1
	University of South Carolina	3	1.1
	The Ohio State University	3	1.1
	Western Washington University	3	1.1
	University of the Arts London	3	1.1
	National University of Singapore	3	1.1
	La Trobe University	3	1.1
	University of Sharjah	3	1.1
	University of Novi Sad	3	1.1
	Total	276	100.0

Table 9

First authors' affiliations in terms of programs/departments.

Program	Frequency	Percent
Valid		
Journalism, Media, and Mass Communication	174	63
Not mentioned	35	12.7
Advertising and Public Relations	20	7.2
Political science	14	5.1
Social Sciences	7	2.5
Business	7	2.5
Management	5	1.8
Marketing	5	1.8
Others	6	2.2
History	3	1.1
Total	276	100.0

as a department, only 5.1% (N = 14) of the articles were published. This also reflects the importance of MR in political areas and practice. In social science and business, 2.5% (N = 7) of the articles each were published. Under management and marketing, N = 5 articles each were published, and history had the lowest number of articles published (N = 3).

The above table shows that the most discussed and interested organizations in MR practice are non-profit organizations, which have 125 articles. Also, the results show that 90 articles investigated governmental organizations, which explains the importance of MR within these organizations. The articles were focused on state-press/MR, such as ministries, presidency periods, security devices, and Army institutions. While 43 articles examined profit-organizations, such as companies that could have less interest in MR mostly because it depends on paid media and ads. Only 35 articles discussed non-government/civil organizations. Mixed organizations are organizations that consider, for example, government universities and also have a profit interest.

4.1. Text-mining of media relations focused research

The word cloud is a sophisticated technique used in discovering and exploring frequency of word occurrence by arranging words a descending order of frequency. So, the most frequently used words become the largest words in the diagram (Zubair Haider & Dilshad, 2015). The following figure shows the word cloud of MR-focused articles.

As in the above figure, Table 9 presents the order arrangement of the word frequency, based on the total numbers and weighted percentages. NVivo's word frequency distribution shows that the most repeated words are "media," "public," "relations," "communication," "news," "press," and "journalist." These words are highly relevant to the core, definition, and discourse of the PR sub-field MR. Other important words are "practitioners," "coverage," "corporate," "organization," "journalism," "management," "crisis," "agenda," "newspapers," "political," "state," "strategic," "journalism," and "government." This explains the key directions and issues that relate directly to the MR area and are discussed within MR scholarship.

In clarifying the major themes and determining the relationship between the main terms, contexts, and discussed issues from the commonly used words in the field, this process illuminated the following repeated themes: *PR strategy, media and journalism, MR management and practice, state and government MR, and corporate and organization MR.*

The present study investigated the most commonly used words to determine the relationship between words and the contexts present in MR articles. The table below provides some operational definitions to help understand the broad themes. These themes are derived from many MR articles and represent the most significant concerns of MR research and discourse. Other themes in the following table were defined based on how articles use it within its context. The definitions were extracted from MR articles and organized in descending order based on the most important and repeated themes (Arqoub et al., 2019). Therefore, most

themes overlap across many articles, so one article could contain various themes. (Tables 10–12).

Overall, this process leads to various important findings. First, MR is a PR sub-field and strategy, and researchers apply PR theories and models while examining it (Cho, 2006; Ciszek, 2020; Fisher, 2017; Holladay & Coombs, 2013; Holtzhausen, 2002; Pang, 2010; Zakakis et al., 2012; Zhang, 2012). Second, mass media outlets and journalists play a crucial role in MR, getting good coverage and being considered the main stakeholders that PR practitioners should understand and build a strategic reciprocal relationship with (Dodson, 2010; Fisher, 2017; Jackson & Moloney, 2016; Macnamara, 2014; Pettigrew & Reber, 2011; Simons & Morgan, 2018; Sinaga & Callison, 2008; Strycharz et al., 2018; Taylor, 2009; Yuezhi, 2000; Yun & Yoon, 2011).

Third, MR has many practical sides that researchers have explored and interpreted within existing scholarship, such as planning, content creation, dimensions, skills, duties, strategies, tactics, tools, principles, and its impact on MR as a profession that many studies have discussed (Hadland et al., 2005; Jung Moon & Hyun, 2014; Kim & Heo, 2018; Martino & Lovari, 2016; Mecfal, 2016; Reber & Kim, 2006; Slutskiy, 2017; Waters et al., 2011). Fourth, many articles in MR scholarship have focused on the relationship between the public state and government organizations, political bodies and parties, and the mass media. Some articles have also focused on examining military and terrorist organizations and leaders (Bishop & Fedorocsko, 2020; Foster, 2012; Ogbondah, 1989; Picard, 1989; Startt, 2010), while others focused on the presidency in the USA (Meyer-Gutbrod & Woolley, 2021; Peake, 2007). Other articles have focused on government press (Kane & Bizimana, 2016; McLean, 1990; Mulherin & Isakhan, 2019; Polytechnic, 1995; Yoo & Kim, 2013).

The last theme discussed MR relates to NGOs as civil organizations and profit organizations as corporations, where each has its criteria and target for using MR. Articles also focused on MR in profit companies and corporations and how to manage the same (Callison, 2003; Gronstedt, 1996; Hou, 2019; Jung Moon & Hyun, 2014; Lee & Riffe, 2017; Pettigrew & Reber, 2010; Schafrad et al., 2016a, 2016b; Verhoeven, 2016). Other articles discussed MR organizational approach for NGOs and civil organizations (Desiere & Sha, 2007; Jun, 2011; Lee & Desai, 2014; Yeon et al., 2007).

5. Discussion and conclusion

The present meta-analysis study provides a significant systematic review of MR articles in the field over the last 77 years. This study was aimed at understanding and shaping the progression, theories, methodologies, data analytical techniques, media genre and platforms, discussed regions, first-authors' affiliations, and discussed organizations in MR-focused articles. A follow-up analysis was conducted using the NVivo 12 program to measure the most commonly used words and the major themes discussed within published MR texts. In this regard, empirical evidence and frequencies show interesting outcomes.

In general, our results show an abundance of MR-focused articles, with a significant increase in the last two decades. For example, academic interest occurred in 2016, when the journal of Public Relations Review published a special issue with the theme "Sleeping (with the) Media" (Vercic et al., 2016). This is evidence that MR is not new

Table 10

Discussed organization types.

Organization Type	Frequency	Percent
Valid		
No Organization	98	35.5
Government Organizations	90	32.6
Profit-organizations (Private Sector and Companies).	43	15.6
Non-Government/Civil Organizations	35	12.7
Mixed Organizations	10	3.6
Total	276	100.0

Table 11

Most frequently used words within MR research (Top 60 words).

Word	Count	Weighted Percentage	Word	Count	Weighted Percentage
1. media	21682	1.78%	studies	1593	0.13%
2. public	17839	1.46%	important	1580	0.13%
3. relations	17297	1.42%	corporate	1574	0.13%
4. news	8168	0.67%	power	1573	0.13%
5. communication	6987	0.57%	people	1531	0.13%
6. press	6936	0.57%	practice	1523	0.12%
7. journalists	5761	0.47%	agenda	1458	0.12%
8. information	5317	0.44%	reporters	1437	0.12%
9. research	4359	0.36%	health	1430	0.12%
10. political	3566	0.29%	American	1379	0.11%
11. government	3403	0.28%	sources	1365	0.11%
12. social	3252	0.27%	war	1353	0.11%
13. practitioners	2847	0.23%	professional	1278	0.10%
14. coverage	2798	0.23%	theory	1273	0.10%
15. organizations	2679	0.22%	business	1271	0.10%
16. journalism	2630	0.22%	society	1270	0.10%
17. relationship	2439	0.20%	strategic	1266	0.10%
18. organization	2434	0.20%	china	1259	0.10%
19. review	2416	0.20%	story	1198	0.10%
20. management	2120	0.17%	world	1192	0.10%
21. work	2081	0.17%	mass	1184	0.10%
22. analysis	2012	0.16%	journalist	1169	0.10%
23. crisis	1998	0.16%	policy	1167	0.10%
24. role	1907	0.16%	newspaper	1166	0.10%
25. international	1898	0.16%	model	1165	0.10%
26. content	1851	0.15%	different	1160	0.10%
27. state	1839	0.15%	communications	1153	0.09%
28. online	1812	0.15%	newspapers	1145	0.09%
29. stories	1660	0.14%	politics	1145	0.09%
30. relationships	1645	0.13%	party	1132	0.09%

sub-field, and it started a long time ago, as shown by the 32 articles that were published from 1945 to 2000. After 2001, articles focused on MR as a clear profession and a mature PR strategy in terms of practical and theoretical aspects. This stands in contrast to other strategies, such as Engineering of Consent that has only 34 articles till 2019 (Arqoub et al., 2019). With respect to modern PR trends, the number of articles decreased in the last four years, from 2018 to 2021, with less focus on subjects related to using social and digital communication technology in the MR process.

Regarding journals that published MR articles, these results were expected. As a PR strategy it is normal for PR journals, media and journalism, and communication journals to publish more articles in this regard. This also strengthens the earlier argument regarding MR being a specific PR area, as discussed in many articles (Feng et al., 2011; Holaday & Coombs, 2013; Zerfass et al., 2016).

With regard to the theoretical framework, MR articles are theory-based research. MR has its own theories and models that originated from communication and PR theories, but they can be adapted and adjusted while examining the MR issue. It is clear that theories, such as agenda-setting, agenda-Building, framing, rhetorical, mediatization, dialogic theory, image repair, contingency, strategic issue management, and social responsibility, and journalist-centric mediating the media model, are the most theoretical frameworks used within MR articles. Historically, agenda-setting and framing theory are favorite theories when examining the media in general, because the media always works to set an agenda for the audience and regarding issues, to make people think about it from a specific frame (Ihlen & Pallas, 2014; Kruvand, 2010; Waters et al., 2010; Wigley & Zhang, 2009). The mediatization theory is consistent with the new term that some researchers call "strategic mediatization" when discussing new MR: "the 20th century gave birth to different kind of media relations, referring to these new forms of mediatized content, the new literature introduces the term strategic mediatization as a new practice supplementing and/or replacing old media relations" (Zerfass et al., 2016, p. 499).

In terms of methodology and data analytical methods, most articles were research-based with a clear scientific method and purpose. The

results show that MR articles adopted qualitative methodology over quantitative methodology. This is consistent with other meta-analyses conducted in the PR and communication fields (Arqoub et al., 2019; Elegu et al., 2022; Li & Tang, 2012). Articles predominantly choose qualitative research methods (interviews, case studies, reviews, historical Analyses). Data analytical techniques in MR articles were primarily focused on content analysis, interviews, surveys, case studies, reviews, and historical analyses. These results demonstrate that MR articles discussed issues and case studies deeply to understand the experiences, phenomena, context, and measured different aspects that qualitative methods help with. For example, this occurred in a study titled "Facing the information void: A case study of Malaysia Airlines' media relations and crisis communication during the MH370 disaster" (Zafra & Maydell, 2018).

In a similar vein, media genre (the type or kind of media generation used in the studied communication process) and media platform (the exact type of media outlets used in the mass communication process to contact the audience) that were examined within MR scholarship show interesting results that traditional media was favorable toward researchers and earned more scholarly attention. Because researchers can easily get access to traditional media archives and—based on the theory believed by researchers that traditional media mainly sets the agenda for the audience and reflects a sound reputation and mental image about the organization—traditional media still has more credibility in the public mind. Traditional media is largely not owned media, and thus requires more effort from PR practitioners to appear on the media (Heath, 2013). Therefore, newspaper and television were the most used platforms for examining MR.

MR as a sub-field is evidently unstimulated by new communication technologies and tools, such as internet, digital and social media, in regard to other PR and communication areas as other meta-analysis shows (Arqoub et al., 2020; Elegu et al., 2022; Wasike, 2017). Hence, organizations' online websites and news websites were the most examined digital media platforms, which is normal when assessing online MR. It starts from the organization website, which provides sound information about itself (Sha, 2011). In contrast, there is a large

Table 12
Major themes of MR-focused articles.

Theme	Operational Definition	Related Repeated Terms
PR Strategy	Articles that present MR from a PR perspective and have to be studied within the PR field. These present MR as a PR strategy and view it as a main function.	(Public, relations, research, practitioners, organizations, management, role, crisis, corporate, practice, agenda, professional, business, strategic, model).
Mass Media and Journalism	Articles that discuss the role of media and journalism as tools and significant professions in the MR process and discuss the changing media landscape, developments, aspects, and effects during traditional media and the digital media age.	(Media, news, press, journalists, information, coverage, journalism, stories, online, content, reporters, sources, mass, newspaper, policy).
MR Practice	Articles that discuss the practical meaning of MR and view the practice of MR as the art of managing relationships with journalists and media outlets, including the professional: content, dimensions, skills, duties, strategies, tactics, principles, etc.	(Practitioners, management, role, practice, agenda, professional, strategic, information, sources, power, public, relations, Media, news, coverage).
State-MR	Articles that discuss the practice of MR for state and government organizations and political bodies. They offer a theoretical framework for state/government MR.	(Political, government, crisis, international, state, power, American, sources, war, party, politics, china, world, policy).
Organizational MR	Articles that discuss the practice of MR within organizations and corporations in different contexts as profit or non-profit organizations, civil organizations, and consider MR as a duty of the PR department within the organization.	(Organizations, management, work, corporate, business, strategic, communications, public, relations, Media, news, press, journalists, coverage).

proportion, almost 61%, that did not examine any media genre or platforms, because it discussed the MR process and the strategy itself from practical and theoretical perspectives.

Social media has enabled much faster communication, and the news cycle has become instantaneous. This changed the way PR practitioners and media interact. Social media platforms have built essential forums that facilitate stronger relationships between PR experts and journalists as well as deeper insight in advance about the topics being covered. Numerous people worldwide get their news from social media every day, which enables brands to be noticed and gain immediate exposure. Social media relations involve content creation and sharing to increase traffic and engagement for organizational awareness and growth. Furthermore, building relations with journalists on social media is a significant matter and is not easy. It requires a deep understanding of how journalists work, what they are seeking, and the best way to reach them. Organizations should take advantage of this by targeting specific audiences and providing a comprehensive social media content strategy (Sha, 2011; Wilson and Supa., 2013).^{1,2}

For PR professionals, it is important to understand the most effective ways to engage with the media outlets and journalists, which facilitates

relationship building on social media platforms through many tactics, such as using social media to connect with journalists, engaging with their content, mentioning relevant social media posts in your pitch, sharing relevant content from your industry, looking for connection points in their feed, sticking to appropriate platforms, sharing journalists' work, reaching out through your personal accounts for establishing trust, and keeping engaging to establish a long-term relationship,³ researching reporters and influencers, joining relevant conversations and respond, commenting on their articles and blog posts, and being helpful by offering useful information.⁴

For regions discussed within the MR articles, North America and the USA had the most articles as, then Europe and UK was had the most articles. These results indicate that developed countries that practice PR professionally have developed organizations and more success cases, being the regions where PR originated. This is consistent with the affiliations of first authors and universities that focus and have an interest in media and PR. With regard to the affiliations of first authors, American researchers and universities have the highest number of articles (136), followed by Europe, with countries focused on MR include UK, Netherlands, and Spain. This is a not a surprising number owing to the American and European level of research productivity. First authors were mostly lecturers or students in these countries at the time of publication. As Grunig (1992) stated, in a paper titled "The Development of Public Relations Research in the United States and its Status in Communication Science," American researchers and schools have published good quantity and quality of PR research, which has clearly affected the sample of the present study. In the same context, the rise of USA's higher education began in the late 1800s, with American universities now having the majority of top-ranked universities all over the world in many fields, such as science, communication, and social science, which started before WWII. This helps increase academic specialization and more precise research output. Over time, schools seek and reward excellent researchers, which attracts talented students and researchers (MacLeod & Urquiola, 2020). Other important factors enable US to have advanced research and talented researchers related to the resources, databases access, government and organizations funding, and availability of consultancy services (Arqoub et al., 2019; Elegu & Özad, 2018; Matthews, 2011).

Various universities worldwide published MR research with no clear high concentration of a specific institution. There were a few universities, such as the University of Kentucky in the US, Nanyang Technological University in Singapore, and the University of Georgia in the US, which published N = 6 articles each. This reflects that there were no specific authors who were interested in MR by writing more papers about the concept, as shown in our review of the articles. This can indicate that there is no clear interest of universities and scholars in such a sub-PR research area, and this is a clear call for universities, journals, and schoolers to be more interested in this area, especially with social media developments and MR implications and practices on social media. Furthermore, we also examined authorship productivity over our sample of study, but we did not find specific authors that published many articles and focused on examining MMR from different angles and views. Hence, there is clearly an absence and scarcity of specialized authors in the MR area and research. Future authors should realize this and produce more specialized research on MR and its practices.

However, communication researchers who are teaching and managing communication programs and departments worldwide have published most MR articles. Although it is important to examine MR in various sectors in all kinds of organizations and entities, it is very important to contribute to the theoretical framework by examining MR from other perspectives, such as health, medical, security devices,

¹ <https://flybluekite.com/social-media-effective-media-relations/>

² <https://www.dearcontent.com/digital-media-relations/>

³ <https://www.prdaily.com/9-ways-pr-pros-can-use-social-media-to-connec-t-with-journalists/>

⁴ <https://flybluekite.com/social-media-effective-media-relations/>

psychological, sociological, political, management, marketing, and history.

In terms of the discussed organization types, non-profit organizations were discussed mostly and most articles investigated MR within governmental organizations and discussed state-press/MR in organizations, such as ministries, presidency periods, security devices, police-MR, and Army institutions (Huey & Broll, 2012; Magen, 2015; Meyer-Gutbrod & Woolley, 2021; Rutland, 1955; Startt, 2010). These results reveal how important MR to organizations and, especially, governments and its institutes, which also relates to the crucial role of PR in delivering a suitable government message to its people (Motion & Kay Weaver, 2005). As Laursen & Valentini (2015) stated, governments want to increase citizens' awareness, support, concerns in political processes through media and press relations. Media should remain faithful to its watchdog role in assisting the strengthening of democracy while governments mostly receive critiques from or through the media, which make relations with media crucial for governments in order to defend or respond to the media and people (Alozieuwa, 2012).

The most often used words within MR scholarship illustrate that most repeated terms are "media," "public," "relations," "communication," "news," "press," and "journalist." This consists of the core role, definition, and principals of MR, which is a main strategy of PR under the communication discipline. Mark Hunter LaVigne defines MR as: "the art and science of reaching your target audience with key messages through the news media" (Carney et al., 2019). Also, to comprehensively understand the context of MR research, five major themes based on the most frequently words emerged and were discussed: Media Relations as a PR Strategy, Media and Journalism, Media Relations Profession and Practice, State-Media Relations, Organizational Media Relations. These themes show the origin of MR as a field and present directions for what researchers have focused on. Thus, MR is a strategy of PR relying on dealing with media and journalism, with the main focus of articles being on organizational MR and especially state-MR, which is consistent with other previous studies and the results of this study (Taylor, 2000). In addition, this mixture of meanings and variables of MR and modern MR is consistent with the new term calling this process a new golden age of MR "strategic mediatization" as mentioned and discussed (Zerfass et al., 2016).

There is a dearth of such research on media relations, despite its prominence in the industry. Media relations should be approached in a holistic and systematic manner, and seasoned practitioners should re-evaluate their current media strategies (Pang et al., 2014). This exploratory study aims to understand MR in the changing media landscape and provide opportunities to conduct applied MR research and practice in countries where the media industry operates in vastly different environments to ensure the viability of MR as a sub-PR area and its aspiration. It also aims to provide a more in-depth understanding of MR in varied socio-political settings. This study can help new practitioners understand the important factors in media relations.

For future research, there is a need for research in MR to focus on specific areas. First, investigating the continues changes in mass communication and its consequences on organizations and MR practice in relation to the new media ecosystem and journalism. Second, more research is needed for examining the new MR that called "strategic mediatization" and the term "mediatizations" in relations to MR strategy and PR. Further, exploring the role of practitioners of PR in the organizational mediatization process constitutes a conceptual and practical perspectives (Ihlen & Pallas, 2014; Zerfass et al., 2016). Third, new studies should explore how MR works on the Internet and who controls the algorithms especially in second- and third-world countries. Research must examine MR using social media platforms. Fourth, in the digital and social media age ethics and etiquette of MR practice are important, further research can explore the abuse of MR concerning how new media and big data enable politicians and governments to manipulate media system and public.

Future research on MR should include the implications of theories

and investigate MR based on suitable, new, and advanced theories, such as the agenda-building/agenda-setting theory with all of its three levels (network agenda setting model), framing theory, mediatization theory, gatekeeping theory, relationship management theory, and journalist-centric mediating the media model, which can guide researchers to direct their research and help PR actioners draw their strategies. These theories must be investigated using new communication tools, such as digital and social media, to shape a clear framework for such usage.

Future studies may also use Hall's cultural context as a theoretical foundation to compare the practices of public relations and media relations in various cultures. According to Hall and Hall's (1990) context theory, different cultures have different ways of communicating: some communicate explicitly (low-context culture), whereas others communicate implicitly (high-context culture). Individuals' cultural backgrounds affect how well they comprehend messages. For example, to optimize humanitarian communication outcomes and motivate audiences through social media to adopt humanitarian attitudes and behaviors of multicultural audiences, researchers should investigate the mediating role of culture by analyzing the influence of context culture on humanitarian behavior intention in two different regions: a low-context-culture country and a high-context-culture country (Alizadeh Afrouzi, 2021).

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